



Conwy Castle

Location Conwy, Wales

Conwy Castle, in north Wales, was one of four castles built by Edward I of England to consolidate his conquest of Wales between 1277 and 1307. By any measure, it is a brutal, brooding structure. It was built on a more or less rectangular plan, its layout dictated by the narrow promontory on

which it sits overlooking the Conwy River. Its limestone walls are 15 ft (4.6 m) thick, and at regular intervals along them are eight massive, circular battlemented towers, each 70 ft (21 m) high. There is a single entrance that originally featured a drawbridge over a deep moat. Within a century, however, gunpowder would render even such a seemingly impregnable fortress obsolete, and by the late 17th century, it had fallen into ruin.

Carcassonne

Location Aude, France

Seen from afar, Carcassonne appears as the model fortified medieval city: perched on a low hill, enclosed within a complete circuit of walls, and topped by towers and spires. In fact, much of the city today is a reconstruction, the brainchild of Eugène Viollet-le-Duc, 19th-century France's

most industrious champion of the past. Medieval Carcassonne was a major fortification, reaching its peak in the 13th century under Louis IX, when it was crucial to the defense of France against the Spanish kingdom of Aragon. With the consolidation of the French monarchy in the mid-15th century, the city's significance inevitably faded. It was revived by Viollet-le-Duc in 1853, when he began the city's remarkable, if not always accurate, reconstruction.